

Jimmy Lee 李兆康

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ACADEMIC POSITIONS

Postdoctoral Fellow in Economics

Global Poverty Research Lab, Northwestern University

Sept 2024 – Present

Visiting Scholar

Center for International Development, Harvard University

Jan 2025 – June 2026

RESEARCH FIELDS

Development Economics, Program Evaluation and Scaling

Focus—Synergies between Agriculture, Rural Education, and Digital Technologies

Family Economics, Organizational Economics

Focus—Intergenerational Dynamics in Rural Household and Community Decision Making

Behavioral Economics

Focus—Endogenous Model Uncertainty and the Economics of Curiosity under Cognitive Limits

EDUCATION

Ph.D., Economics, Northwestern University

2024

M.Phil., Economics, The Chinese University of Hong Kong

2017

B.SSc., Economics, The Chinese University of Hong Kong

2015

JOB MARKET PAPER

“Miscategorization as an Information Friction? Activating School-Based Agricultural Extension in Liberia with Parental Engagement”

(Funded by AFD Fund for Innovation in Development, USAID-DIV, Wellspring Foundation, and FAO)

Schools in developing countries often have weak ties with parents. This paper examines the extent to which programs with innovative elements—which parents may misperceive—hinge on strengthening these ties to succeed. In a three-year Liberian experiment across 197 schools, I evaluate school-based agricultural extension (SBAE) against control, cross-randomizing whether to inform parents about SBAE’s distinctive, inquiry-based learning features via promotional videos and field days. SBAE improves targeted outcomes only when paired with parental engagement: students’ households adopt 26–53% more agricultural techniques, dropouts fall 4–5 percentage points per year, absenteeism falls 28%, and studying hours rise 22%. The program is among the most cost-effective extension programs in randomized trials in sub-Saharan Africa, and over twice as cost-effective as a widely cited cash-transfer benchmark for the region (Baird et al. 2011). SBAE has strong positive training effects on students that are unaltered by parental engagement. However, without parental engagement, SBAE’s diffusion mechanisms via school demonstration farms, home projects, and intra-household communication stay muted—technology adoption effects vanish, absenteeism rises 31%, studying hours fall 20%, and parents disconnect—reducing school farm visits 12% and parent–teacher meetings 39%. Parents’ persistent avoidance of information about a new program, plus sharply reversed responses to SBAE under engagement, pose a puzzle. I discuss how standard Bayesian updating under a fixed prior, selective attention, and associative memory each fall short as standalone explanations. I propose an integrative explanation: parental engagement shifts parents’ categorization of SBAE away from schemas such as “school gardens as drudgery” or “parents are not involved.”

WORKING PAPERS

1. “Technology Adoption and Schooling as Complements: The Promise of School-Based Agricultural Extension in Africa” (joint with Chris Udry)

In sub-Saharan Africa, wide heterogeneity across farms makes other households’ experience a noisy guide to what suits a household’s own farms, slowing technology diffusion, while low perceived returns to schooling drive students to drop out. We develop a model of why school-based agricultural extension (SBAE), which combines inquiry-based science learning, school demonstration plots, student home projects, and leadership training, addresses this dual problem. Our model builds on the target-input

framework, in which a household learns a technology's suitability only by using it in production or by observing others who do. We add a third channel: the more of a child's time the household devotes to schooling, the more precisely it learns from the school's production signals. Schooling and technology adoption become complements. First, schooling carries an option value on the farm: by raising the probability of future adoption, it makes attendance worthwhile even where labor-market returns are low. Second, SBAE effectively subsidizes information acquisition by delivering information through schooling, whose cost households already bear for its educational returns, countering the under-supply of information in the presence of learning spillovers. We provide experimental evidence from Liberia that SBAE cost-effectively raises both agricultural technology adoption and school attendance, and use extensions of the model to study how SBAE's design can be strengthened, including (i) how effectively inquiry-based learning raises the marginal informational return to schooling, and (ii) how effectively SBAE's home visits aggregate households' dispersed knowledge and feed it back to them.

2. **“Endogenous Model Uncertainty and Curiosity under Cognitive Limits”**

People actively assign meaning to what they see and predict from it, and whether they look for more information depends on the mental model they use. People can self-correct, but this can be hindered when the space of model exploration strains cognitive limits. Model-switching and associative-memory models of categorization capture this partially: they allow one model at a time and abstract from information acquisition. I model contextual shifts in “mindsets” as a choice of how much model uncertainty to entertain: after an initial signal, a decision maker with a default mental model and latent, less precise alternatives jointly chooses how much attention to give each and how much information to acquire. The key discipline is a neurally grounded evidence constraint that bounds motivated beliefs: an alternative's weight is capped by its Bayesian posterior. Curiosity then arises endogenously as a drive to resolve model uncertainty created by evidence for an alternative. The model links behavioral puzzles in belief updating and information acquisition. It isolates new mechanisms for two effects central to memory models. First, context effects: payoff-irrelevant context has limited effects, because it sways decisions only when another model makes it relevant, and the search this triggers reverses the shift if that model proves wrong. Second, interference effects: rather than changing which model comes to mind, rival explanations can dilute one another's support, leaving none activated and search dormant. I illustrate design principles where stimulating continuous model exploration is crucial: drawing parents' attention to school-based agricultural extension and promoting new teaching, learning, and farming approaches among teachers, students, and farmers.

3. **“Can Communicating Parents' Beliefs to Students Be a Pivotal Component of Parental Engagement? Evidence from School-Based Agricultural Extension in Liberia”**

(Funded by NSF, Weiss Fund, Global Poverty Research Lab, and the Buffett Institute for Global Affairs)

When school programs require students to introduce improved techniques on household farms, is informing students and parents about the program sufficient, or is there a case for further signaling parents' support to students? I study this question within a randomized evaluation of school-based agricultural extension (SBAE) in Liberia, where students take school farm training into a home farming project. After parents view a promotional video of the program and students are encouraged to diffuse techniques to their parents, I randomize a nudge revealing to students their parents' optimism about their farm-management skills. Two years later, SBAE improves students' livelihoods only with the nudge: income rises 63%, on-time school fee payment 43–47%, and cost-effectiveness for attendance doubles. Analysis of mechanisms highlights a management aspect of agricultural technology adoption that can be addressed with nudges: even where parents become attentive to SBAE and adopt promoted techniques, third-party assurance can be pivotal in shifting students away from assisting in subsistence farming.

WORK IN PROGRESS

Ongoing Randomized Experiments (scaling SBAE across Liberia, Côte d'Ivoire, and Kenya in 2026-35)

1. **“Learning to Learn: Synergizing Inquiry-based Science and Agricultural Transformation in Liberia”** (joint with Vesall Nourani, Harvard GSE; scheduled RCT within the scaling of SBAE in 2026-29)
2. **“Parental Engagement in School-based Agricultural Extension: Testing Mechanisms at Scale”** (piloted interventions in 2025-26)
3. **“Parental Engagement and the Use of Unconditional Cash Transfers”**
4. **“Directed Technical Change under Data-Driven Farming Advice: An Empirical Framework”** (grant from Weiss Fund; piloted survey method; planning RCT)

GRANTS AND AWARDS

Total program evaluation and academic research grants secured for SBAE in Liberia: \$4.2 million

Program Evaluation Grants

AFD Fund for Innovation in Development (\$1.2 mil; co-PI)	2025
J-PAL Learning for All Initiative: Scaling Award (\$222K; co-PI)	2024
USAID Development Innovation Ventures (\$395K; co-PI)	2022
Wellspring Foundation (\$192K; co-PI)	2022
AFD Fund for Innovation in Development (\$1.2 mil; co-PI)	2021
Food and Agriculture Organization (\$68K; co-PI)	2021

Academic Research Awards

J-PAL Learning for All Initiative (\$400K; co-PI)	2025
Weiss Fund (\$5K; Lead PI)	2022
National Science Foundation (\$451K; co-PI)	2020
Weiss Fund (\$29K; Lead PI)	2020
Global Poverty Research Lab (\$19K; Lead PI)	2019
Buffett Institute for Global Affairs (\$5K; Lead PI)	2019

INVITED PRESENTATIONS

During postdoctoral studies:

National Chung Cheng University; NYU Africa House—Center for Technology, Economics, and Development (CTED); Mohammed VI Polytechnic University (UM6P); Tel Aviv University; Oklahoma State University; Harvard Center for International Development; Africa Food Systems Forum 2024

During PhD:

Meeting of the Society of Economics of the Household (SEHO); J-PAL—Middle East and North Africa (MENA); CGIAR—Standing Panel on Impact Assessment (SPIA); International Food Policy Research Institute (IFPRI); University of Glasgow; National Graduate Institute for Policy Studies (GRIPS, Tokyo); Development Day 2023

TEACHING

Teaching Assistant, Northwestern University (Department median 5.3/6)

Introduction to Microeconomics (5.2, 5.4, 5.6), Introduction to Macroeconomics (5.4, 5.4), Intermediate Microeconomics (5.4), Intermediate Macroeconomics (5.7), International Trade (5.6), Economics of Nonprofit Organizations (5.8)

Teaching Assistant, The Chinese University of Hong Kong

Mathematical Methods in Economics I, II, Family Economics, International Macroeconomics

LANGUAGES AND SKILLS

Citizenship: Hong Kong Special Administrative Region, China

Languages: English (fluent), French (intermediate), Mandarin (fluent), Cantonese (native)

Programming: Stata, R, Matlab, Python, ArcGIS, SurveyCTO

REFERENCES

Professor Christopher Udry (Chair)

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Professor Lori Beaman

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